

OVERVIEW

Are you eager to discuss real real-world questions in math class, but also feel a little nervous that you (or your students) might “say the wrong thing” when the conversation touches on potentially sensitive issues? In this conversation, you’ll explore how to approach sensitive topics in a way that fosters a respectful, constructive, and authentic conversation.

SPARK MEDIA & FOCUS LESSON

Classroom Dialogue

Imagined student comments during the lesson [Seeking Shelter](#).

PEDAGOGICAL THEME

Focusing on the Real World

USING THE CONVO GUIDE FOR A GREAT ROUNDTABLE DISCUSSION

- This conversation is designed for a group of 2-5 educators over 30-60 minutes.
- The Convo Guide serves as an agenda for a roundtable conversation where everyone is there both to learn and to share their expertise.
- Each participant should have their own copy of the Convo Guide and access to the Spark Media.
- Pace yourselves to get through the entire agenda in the time you have.
- Questions aren’t intended to have a single right answer; instead, they’re designed to spark rich discussions.
- At the end, everyone will commit to trying “one small thing” the very next day. Consider how you might follow up with one another!

OBSERVE

5–15 MIN

- To start, take a look at the Spark Media.
- How might others (students and yourself) feel about or react to these comments?
- How might these comments impact the classroom conversation?

DISCUSS

10–15 MIN

- Consider one or two of the comments from the samples above. What are some helpful ways the teacher could respond in the moment? What do you think would be unhelpful?
- Before the lesson even begins, what should the teacher do to set the stage for a productive conversation in which all students feel comfortable?

RELATE

10–15 MIN

- Thinking about your own students, what kind of skills, dispositions, and classroom culture would help them to have productive conversations about sensitive topics?
- What could you do to build those skills, dispositions, and culture in your classroom?

...AND COMMIT!

5–10 MIN

- What is one small thing you can do tomorrow in support of those shifts?

IMAGINED STUDENT COMMENTS

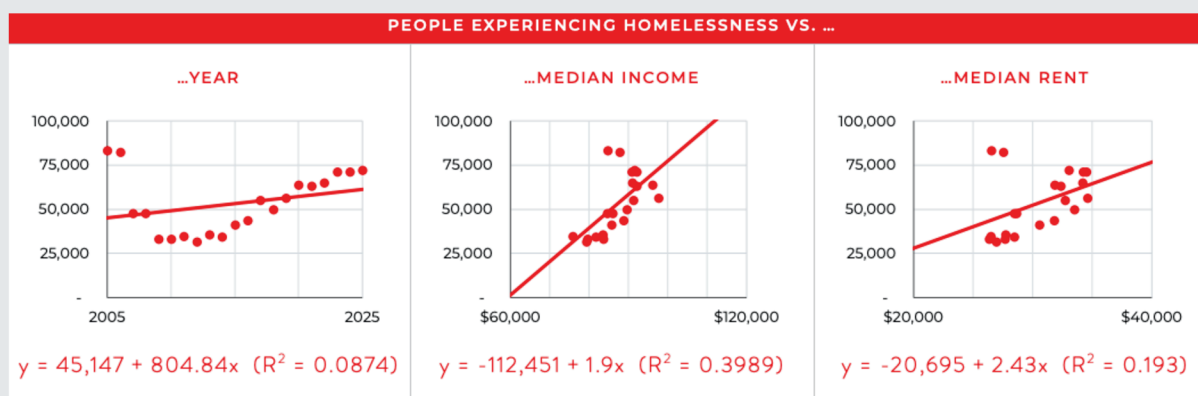
It's valuable and important that students connect their learning to real-world issues that matter. But it can also feel a little risky: What if my students (or I!) say "the wrong thing" and someone gets hurt?

Below are some comments that one teacher feared might come up during the Citizen Math lesson Seeking Shelter in which students interpret linear models of data to explore what influences homelessness.

EXCERPT FROM QUESTION 3

At any given moment in the United States, there are more than 700,000 people experiencing homelessness. Many of these people become homeless when they could no longer afford to pay their rent. Watch the video about some of these people.

Next, look at the graphs below, and describe the story they tell about homelessness in Los Angeles from 2005 to 2025. Would you conclude that there's a strong relationship between how expensive a city is and how many people experience homelessness there?



When median income rose, the landlords raised rent which caused homelessness to rise, too. ...Ugh, landlords are so greedy!

Why are we talking about homelessness when we don't even have homeless people in our town?

What is "rent" anyway? All I know is that my dad says buying a house is always a better investment than renting.

Are we supposed to talk about this in math class?

As rents rose, so did homelessness – because those people couldn't afford rent anymore. But why not just get a second job...or move to a cheaper place instead of sleeping on the streets?